

Ethnic BALANCE

As a movement, it has succeeded in making Tamils conscious of their legacy as much as it has asserted the region's inalienable right to be an indivisible part of India

■ By Karthigesu Sivathamby

Since the first Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) cabinet was formed by Conjeevaram Nadarajan Mudaliayar Annadurai in the Madras Province in 1967, Tamil Nadu has to this day been ruled by a Dravidian party. Jawaharlal Nehru once expressed surprise over the DMK demand for a Dravida Nadu, but today all the Lok Sabha seats in the state are in the hands of the Democratic Progressive Alliance (DPA) led by DMK. Such is the sway the term 'Dravidian' holds over the political imagination of the Tamil Nadu populace.

The year 1916 was significant. That was when Maraimalai Adikal (Swami Vethachalam) launched the pure Tamil movement against the use of Sanskrit words in Tamil. The same year, big non-Brahmin landlords produced the non-Brahmin manifesto arguing for reservation in the provision of government jobs. They formed the South Indian Liberal Federation and ran a journal called *Justice*, which led to them becoming known as the Justice Party. There was a political need for an ethno-cultural name in the then Madras Presidency that would bring the Kappus of Karnataka, the Reddys of Andhra, the Pillais and Mudaliyars of Tamil Nadu, and the Nairs of Kerala into one fold. The term 'Dravidian' slowly emerged from the cultural ethos as the popular choice but was not used politically till later. The British rule of law promised social equality but



it was denied to the non-Brahmin castes. The experiences of the local Congress committee secretary Erode V. Ramasamy Naicker at the Vaikom Satyagraha compelled him to start the Self-Respect Movement in 1926. Naicker later came to be known as Periyar or the great elder.

The social exclusion of all the non-Brahmin castes led to the rejection of Brahminic religion as an institution and resulted in a call for rationalism. The first cry for rationalism was raised by Ayothi Das in the mid-19th century. It couldn't succeed but the desire for it wasn't extinguished either. Periyar made rationalism an integral part of the Self-Respect Movement and was violently anti-Brahminic. He also argued for social reforms and stood for social democratisation. The Justice Party, for its survival, sought the assistance of Periyar, who, by the 1930s, had given up the socialist cause. In 1944, Periyar founded the Dravida Kazhagam (DK) combining elements of the Justice Party and Self-Respect Movement. By 1944, Dravidism had become part of the country's political lexicon with DK standing for social reform, atheism and the eschewal of electoral politics.

The then DK secretary, C.N. Annadurai, a central figure in the state's political history, launched DMK a year after Independence. He brought in strategic

MARGUERITE BARNETT, Chicago University, 1972

"Tamilians see themselves as a nation with an intrinsic legitimacy of its own."